THEY AIM TO MAIM

The heartland states have seen an alarming rise in 'half encounter' cases where alleged offenders are shot in the leg by the police. With the courts stepping in, the 'instant justice' discourse is facing a backlash

By Amitabh Srivastava, Rahul Noronha and Avaneesh Mishra

When a video clip of masked men molesting a Class X student in Jamui, Bihar, went viral on September 19, it triggered outrage across the country. It also punctured the narrative that law and order in Bihar had improved after the BJP government came to power in the state. Three days later, the Bihar police paraded the alleged main accused, Nandan Yadav, limping after being shot in the leg. The police made the usual claim: that he had shot at them when they went to arrest him near Kundar Barrage on the Jamui Lakhisarai road, and that he was injured when they returned fire. In Bihar, such incidents of what is widely perceived as extra-judicial punitive retribution have earned a name of their own: 'half encounter'.

The name changes to 'short encounters' in Madhya Pradesh, but the practice remains the same. In early September, a hooch tragedy killed more than 20 people in Sagar district (unofficial versions put the death toll above 50). During the course of the investigation, 25 people were arrested, but the three kingpins, Manish Lodhi, Ravi Lakhera and Shivanjay Rajput, were shot in the leg in separate incidents.

In Uttar Pradesh, the term is more direct: 'Operation Langda (cripple)'. The force does not acknowledge it as a formal strategy, and senior officers deny there is any deliberate attempt to maim suspects. But the numbers do point to a striking pattern. Since March 2017, when the BJP government led by Yogi Adityanath came to power, the UP Police have shot and injured at least 11,834 alleged criminals in 17,043 encounters. In an overwhelming number of such cases, the bullet wounds were on the legs. The police claim they do not maintain data on how many have been left permanently disabled.

Part of the BIMARU heartland, Bihar, MP and UP have not always been model states when it comes to law and order. 'Encounter' deaths have always been part of the police playbook, but 'deterrence', too, has become part of the script in the past decade or so. The action unfolds in a remarkably similar fashion: the police receive a tip-off locating the accused in





Video grabs enhanced by AI